

“Yes, I’m afraid so,” Jackson responded a little defiantly. “It’s the medical bills for the baby.”

“We know the bills must be a problem for you and Linn, and we’re working on something that might help. But the garnishment is the result of a judgment from a Visa bill. Is that related to the medical expenses?”

“No, not directly,” Jackson said, looking down at the floor as he spoke. “We’ve had to use our credit cards for normal expenses during the last few months. But it all started because of the baby’s problems.”

Then Nick began to realize that Jackson had allowed the problems with the baby to distort his thinking. He said, “Jackson, I believe you have more financial problems than just the medical bills from the baby. I know we don’t pay our teachers nearly what the public school systems do, and it’s tough to make it on one salary, but you took the job knowing that, and now I suspect that even without the baby you would be in over your head. I want you to go to a financial coach and get a clear picture of where you are financially. There is a potentially embarrassing situation developing through this whole thing.”

“How so?” Jackson asked. “Will I lose my job over the garnishment?”

“No,” Nick responded. “We have neither the right nor the authority—nor the desire—to dismiss you for that reason. But with Linn not working, you would have a difficult time making ends meet even if all your finances were in perfect order. We do have some teachers supporting families on one salary, but they must be very careful and live on a strict budget. With this garnishment I know your budget won’t make it. Do you have other debts besides the Visa?”

“Well, yes, we do,” Jackson responded uncomfortably.

“More than three thousand dollars?”

“Well, yes, I guess so, but we’ve decided to file for bankruptcy anyway. The medical bills would make it impossible to live on my